THE SHE LIST UNDER 50

THE **SPORTSWOMEN**

A Grip on Glory

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Antim Panghal has become a worthy successor to the other most decorated Indian female wrestler of our time, Vinesh Phogat, by attaining rank World No. 1 in the women's 53 kg category (2025) as well as winning bronze at the World Championships and Asian Championships last year

The youngest female wrestler from India to reach the Olympics had her high slashed brutally when, in a shock defeat, she was knocked out in the first round at the 2024 Paris edition. Yet Antim Panghal, not even 21 at the time, had already won the U20 World Championship two years in a row, won bronze at three world events—the Asian Games, Asian Championships and World Championship—and had been branded the United World Wrestling's (UWW) Rising Star of 2023. She'd not put one foot wrong. Till then.

"I had to heal first," she says. And it wasn't just physical recovery. The bout had borne a psychological effect—what would need to be cultivated is a healthy attitude to defeat. So now, two years lat-



ALAMY

ROLE MODEL

"The one name we have all heard growing up was that of Sushil (Kumar) *pehelwanji*. If I have a role model, it's him. I'd want to be like him"